Because I Want You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30750872.

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Explicit

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

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angsty lesbians, Canon Divergence, First Time, Semi-Public Sex, Angst, cunninglingus, Vaginal Fingering, Adora transforms into She-ra during sex, Character Study, POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, this is sad and i'm sorry, but it has a happy ending, no beta we die like men, Explicit Consent

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by Asphyxia

Summary

[Canon Divergence: Failsafe] Before Catra leaves, Adora breaks down and admits what she wants and Catra is desperate to give it to her.
(This is basically an angsty smut fic about them spending what they assume is going to be Adora's last night alive together that doubles as an Adora character study)

Notes

When I was originally planning this fic out it wasn't long at all, it was just to answer my question of "what if Adora had been honest with Catra when she asked what she wanted?" and I intended to just explore that, but then the emotions were too high to keep it brief so. It ended up going beyond just the super emotional sex. So I'm sorry for the length and I hope it's still enjoyable even at 12,000+ words!

Title is from the Placebo song because of course I'd name my first angsty Catradora fic after a Placebo song.

See the end of the work for more notes

“What do you want, Adora?”

The question hangs in the air between them. The soft breeze that rustles through the trees and drags the heavily perfumed scent of the Whispering Woods to Catra’s sensitive nose seems to carrying the words up into the sky and far away before anything comes out of Adora’s mouth. The fact that she doesn’t know how to answer, doesn’t answer the desperate plea that Catra is sending her with her eyes…it makes Catra’s heart crush and shatter into a billion pieces that Adora just stomps on when she does finally answer.

“I…I have to do this, Catra. I’m the only one who can.” There it is, the infuriating need to always be the *hero*, to be what everyone else wants. Catra really believed, even just for a short time, that Adora returned her feelings, that she wanted her the same way she does. But it’s clear now that nothing has changed at all. Adora has always been so infuriatingly obedient, so willing to please in all situations that she’ll throw away whatever she has for the sake of being the hero everyone wants, for the sake of feeding that massive ego of hers. If only she knew…if only she knew how much she always hurts Catra in the process.

The sadness inside her wells up to a breaking point, the tears on her face breaking free and rolling down her cheeks, and then the pain fractures into the sharp edges of anger and her face crumples into a rough scowl, piercing Adora with eyes that say all the things she wants to yell at her, but she doesn’t. She holds herself back, holds in her temper like she’s been trying so hard to do, even though it would feel so good to come unglued on her right now.

“Then do it,” she tells the blonde who’s just sitting there on the ground, clutching Catra’s discarded backpack and looking lost and hurt. Catra can’t bring herself to let that tortured expression on her face to bring her back to her. “That’s what you want. That’s what you’ll always choose.” Her voice breaks on the last syllable, and she turns to walk away, Melog chirping inquisitively as they rush to her side. She brushes a hand over their smooth coat for

comfort and they give a slightly more worried chirp, asking if she's okay, and she squeezes her eyes shut and starts walking into the woods.

"Catra, please, stay. I need you."

There it is. That word. *Need*. Adora *needs* her. But she doesn't want her. Catra stops, just long enough to take one last painful look back at the girl sitting pitifully on the ground clutching a backpack.

"No you don't. You never have."

Adora doesn't need her, even if she thinks she does. Adora needs her so she can feel like the hero, needs to protect her to soothe her own painful guilt. Adora doesn't want; she needs. Adora will only admit that she has the impulse to be pulled toward *anything* if she requires it. It's the secret ingredient to her being able to let go enough to *have* anything. Adora can only have something if she requires it, if her brain deems it necessary for her to keep going down that selfless path that's still somehow, somehow tinged with selfishness. She's so infuriatingly stubborn and impossible to get through to, like talking to a brick wall. She's always been this way. It makes Catra sad, but it also makes her blood boil, and she focuses on that feeling instead, clings onto it with figurative claws even sharper than her literal ones as she walks away with purpose, leaving Adora behind. She knows she'll never see her again; Adora is likely going to die when she takes the failsafe to the Heart, and that tears her apart inside. But she might not, and if she leaves now then she'll never have to know. In her mind, Adora will always still be sitting there on the forest floor outside of the shelter they were sleeping in, still alive and frozen in time. Catra knows it's cowardly, but she can't let herself stay and watch her die.

Catra reaches out to Melog, caressing their head gently and telling them without words with their connection that she's ready to go, and just as she feels her body start to go warm and weightless as Melog teleports the two of them far, far away from the girl who's

been the source of every moment of heartbreak and happiness she's ever felt for her entire life, suddenly Adora's voice cuts out into she silence and slices through her resolve in an instant, like She-ra's sword through butter.

"Catra, I want *you*!"

Melog's teleport stops as suddenly as it began, without Catra even having to tell them to stop it, and she spins around to see Adora walking toward her, her hands clenched into fists at her sides and she moves with purpose. Catra can feel her eyes practically bulging out of her head. Her ears are good. Her ears are *great*. There's no way she misheard what Adora said. She's just having trouble actually believing that she said it.

"What?" she asks, just wanting to hear it again, and Adora stops just a few feet from her, her eyebrows knitted in a determined frown as she stands in front of her like she's on the frontlines of a battle, and she doesn't disappoint, locking those intense, trembling pale blue eyes with Catra's as she says it *again*.

"I want you." This time she says it softly, and Catra's heart skips a beat, her cheeks flushing. Her mouth goes dry. Adora looks at the ground, and when she looks back up at her her cheeks are red too. Catra is amazed. "You asked what I wanted and I didn't…I couldn't…"

"Adora…" her own voice sounds so small to her own ears, so weak.

"I know I have to do this, even if I might not survive it. I don't have a choice. It's the only way we can protect Etheria from him getting the weapon. But I'm the only one who even has a chance to survive it, and I have to take that risk to make sure I'm not… letting someone else die with no possibility that they could be okay. You might not understand it, and I can't expect you to stay and…have to watch if the worst happens. I know it's hard, and I can't possibly ask that of you. But I just…I just wanted you to know. That you're what I want. That I want you by my side not

because of the Rebellion or because of how you're helping us. But because of *you*. I want *you*, Catra."

For a moment, Catra has no idea how to respond. Adora's words stick into her chest and piece back together some of the shards of her heart, but they also make them bleed because she's saying this…she's saying this and she's probably going to die.

Catra meets her eyes, and they just stare at each other for a moment, neither of them speaking. Catra swallows hard, the tears that were streaking down her face forgotten in the turmoil and starting to dry in the breeze. There are so many things Catra wants to say, so many questions she wants to ask Adora that she's scared of the answer to. She wants to ask if she loves her, but either way the answer would be too painful. Her heart is hammering in her chest and her breathing is starting to come shallow, her hands shaking at her sides, her brain going in a million different directions at once, unable to even form a single coherent thought. The only thing that she can pin down is the thought that she needs to kiss Adora. Absolutely *has* to. This might be her only chance. She takes a step forward, closing more of the distance between them, and she reaches out a hand and places it on Adora's upper arm, squeezing it firmly.

"Say it again," she hears herself say, and Adora smiles sadly, the breeze catching the bits of her hair that have come loose and making them flutter against her face.

"I want you," she breathes, and Catra uses the hand on her arm to push her against the nearest tree, crushing her lips to hers before she loses her nerve.

Adora lets out a tiny startled noise against her lips as Catra kisses her, but she doesn't pull away. The kiss isn't tender like Catra had intended it to be; it's desperate and pleading and it's clumsy and crushing. She tastes blood and she's sure one of her fangs nicked Adora's lip a bit. As a first kiss, it definitely isn't ideal, but Catra doesn't care. Tonight is the last opportunity she has, and she's going to take what she can get. It takes Adora a moment to kiss

her back and when she does it's equally as desperate, one of her hands coming up to clutch the front of her shirt and the other grabbing her shoulder. Adora's always touched her shoulder in emotional situations and there's something so different in the way she does it while she's kissing her.

She's kissing her. Catra is kissing Adora. And Adora is kissing her back.

Catra can barely even believe this is real. Her senses are telling her it's happening but for a moment she almost wonders if this is somehow another one of Prime's illusions, because there's no way a world where Adora would actually kiss her back exists, right?

Wrong, apparently, because Adora is absolutely all too real, she's too warm and awkward about kissing her back to possibly be a fantasy and she's pulling Catra closer, the curves of her body melding with Catra's perfectly, *too* perfectly. It's overwhelming in the most delicious way. She's been close to Adora so many times but never like this, never with their lips locked together and this *heat* between them that simmers and burns and threatens to consume Catra completely.

Adora kisses her like her life depends on it, her hands that cling to her shaking and her blunt nails digging into her skin through her clothes. If Catra hadn't believed her words, she would believe them now. She can practically *feel* Adora's want searing through every motion of her lips against hers, in the way she sucks at her bottom lip in a way that tears as wanton moan from Catra's lips. Catra circles her arms around her tightly as Adora's tongue darts into her mouth and finds her own, rolling against it and Catra meets it hungrily, relishing the way the other woman gasps against her mouth as her claws start to knead rather roughly at her lower back, all rational thought chased away at the taste of her kisses that threaten to rip Catra apart.

When Adora says her name in a tone she's never heard her use before, desperate and breathless and full of want, when she pulls at her shirt where her hand is still clasped in such a rough and

demanding way, Catra swears she nearly passes out. She's got Adora pressed up against a tree and she's kissing the life out of her and somehow it's still Adora who has the upper hand, who's making *Catra* lose control. It's always been this way. Adora has always had so much of her and Catra wonders if Adora even *knows*.

She pulls back to look at her. Adora chases her lips for a few inches and Catra wants to smirk smugly at the way she practically begs her to kiss her again, but she can't. She's far too breathless and lost in the moment, and she looks at her with reverence instead. The failsafe sigil on Adora' chest is glowing again, pulsing a bright pink that's almost blinding and it bathes both of them in its light. Catra doesn't recall seeing it do this before. It's with a pit in her stomach that the sight of it reminds her all over again what's probably going to happen, but the soft look Adora is giving her chases away those thoughts for the moment, though it unfortunately doesn't do anything to quell the ache in her chest. Catra wants to kiss her again, but stops herself, dropping one arm from around Adora's waist to tuck an escaped lock of golden hair behind her ear. A soft sigh leaves Adora's lips at the gesture.

"What do you want, Adora?" she asks her plaintively, locking her eyes with the blonde's and not letting her look away. "Right now?"

Adora bites her lip, trying to look at her feet but Catra chases her gaze. "Catra, I don't…"

"No," Catra argues, shaking her head. "I'm sick of that. You're always doing whatever. Whatever you *need* to do. Whatever everybody else wants. I want to hear what *you* want right now. It matters, okay? Especially to me. Please."

It seems like the please does it. Adora chews on her lip briefly and then she leans her head forward, capturing Catra's lips again and kissing her with renewed vigor. Her hands moving to run up Catra's sides, one caressing along the length of her tail that she can reach as she finds her tongue again and before long she has

Catra breathless, her hands shaking as she clasps her arms around Adora's back again and tries to keep herself steady.

"I want to taste you," Adora gasps against her mouth, and Catra can feel her cheeks flush. She doesn't want to read too much into what she's saying, but then Adora moves her mouth to her neck and presses a trail of kisses there, starting out chaste but ending in the sort of kisses that make her head swim. "That's what I want. If things go…badly…then I at least want to have done that. Is that okay?"

Catra decides that whether or not she wants to let her brain indulge in reading into what Adora's saying, whatever it could end up culminating in, she doesn't care. She wants it. She wants everything she's willing to give her, everything she *wants* to give her.

"*Yes*," she whispers breathlessly, tilting her head back to give Adora better access to her neck, and she doesn't disappoint. She peppers hungry kisses up and down the expanse of her throat, pulling back the stretchy fabric of her top enough to gain access to the place where her neck meets her shoulder. Catra just drowns in it, just lets Adora do what she wants and marvels at how it's exactly what she's always wanted but has never been able to ask for.

The kisses on her neck stop long enough for Adora to grab the bottom of the top half of her bodysuit, tugging on it questioningly as she pulls back to meet Catra's eyes. Her cheeks are flushed and she's sure her own are too. Catra can see Melog moving out of the corner of her eye, heading politely back to the shelter where the others sleep, and she sends them a quick 'thanks', relieved that anything further won't have an audience.

"Is this okay?" Adora asks cautiously, and Catra nods fervently, her hand touching one of Adora's encouragingly. Adora pulls the garment over Catra's head with some difficultly and she lifts her arms to help her. When the piece of fabric is tossed aside Catra is left totally nude from the waist up and she feels completely

vulnerable for the first time since they got back to Etheria, and it's like Adora *knows*. She reaches out to touch her so gently, stepping away from the tree and guiding Catra by the hands to the place she herself occupied before, tenderly coaxing her back to the tree. The smooth bark of the tree is warm against her exposed back and it soothes some of the tension in her body.

"It's okay," Adora whispers, and she's smiling at her so gently that Catra just lets go, leans her head against the tree and just surrenders to Adora completely. Adora starts slower this time, peppering gentle kisses over her cheeks, and Catra lunges for her mouth impatiently and kisses her desperately, trying to show her it's okay, that she wants this too, and Adora meets her kiss with just as much intensity.

They're all clumsy lips and tongues and maybe a little teeth because they're still both new to this, but they make it work. Adora's hands wander up to Catra's chest and she leans into her touch, reveling in the warmth of her hands and the roughness of the callouses on her fingertips and palms as she caresses her breasts gently with both hands. Catra's lips falter against Adora's as she moans softly into her touch. They're still fairly close to the shelter where the others are sleeping and she wonders briefly if they'll be able to hear anything, but she only cares for a moment. She wants this. They both want this. It might be the last chance they'll get to have it. The circumstances don't matter at all. It isn't the love confession she hoped she'd get to give Adora, but that would be too painful now; if Adora doesn't feel the same, she could live with that, but if she returned her feelings…if they shared that moment and then she lost Adora forever that would be a scar on her heart that would never disappear. It's better just to have this, this brief fleeting moment that until now had only existed in her fantasies, something solid and tangible she can hold onto, than to delve into the depths of what might have been if things were different.

"You feel so nice…" Adora whispers, dragging Catra from her thoughts, and she hums softly in response, her hands playing at Adora's waist as she continues to caress her. Adora's hands are

what feels nice. That's the only thing she can think. But she's too out of it to even say it. Adora kisses her a little slower now as she explores her chest, her hands worshipping her skin in a way that makes her body shake and her thoughts race and center to a single point that blinds her with its intensity.

'I love you, I love you, I love you'

When Adora's fingertips smooth over her nipples in little circles and then she starts to roll them gently between two fingers each, Catra keens, pushing her chest against her hands in appreciation. Her brain goes blank of all her painful thoughts and all she can focus on is the sensations Adora is giving her, the touches that make her nerve endings feel like they're full of sparks and stars. This is what Adora wants. *She* is what Adora wants. It's almost too much to believe, but Adora gives her no choice but to believe it. She's kissing her so tenderly but so passionately, her tongue rolling languidly against her own as she continues to play with her nipples. It's almost too much. Adora breaks the kiss and peppers a slow trail of chaste ones along her jaw before she starts lavishing her neck with passionate ones that send sparkling trails of heat between her legs. Catra is worried she won't be able to stand up for much longer.

The kisses get progressively lower, moving in a long stripe along her collarbone and to her shoulder before they trail to her chest. Adora's lips seem a little more hesitant there and she kisses her left breast slowly, gently, so chaste that when she moves her hand from her nipple to cup her breast instead and her mouth moves to where her fingers touched before, Catra *whimpers* in surprise, pushing her chest into Adora's mouth, one of her hands coming up to the back of Adora's neck, her claws kneading into her gently as Adora starts to alternate between swirling her tongue around her nipple and sucking it gently between her lips. Her mouth feels even better than her hand and Catra trembles. Adora's other hand is still on her other breast but her fingers just caress her lazily there, clearly distracted by what she's doing with her tongue. Adora switches to her other breast with her mouth and the breeze on her wet skin is a stark contrast to her hot mouth, but the

discomfort is brief because Adora's hand cups the neglected breast and starts to massage it gently as her mouth on the other tears her self-control apart.

When Adora's mouth and hand leave her chest, Catra whimpers in protest and Adora kisses her, a slow gentle kiss before she pulls back and tucks a few fingers under the waistband of her leggings, meeting her eyes with uncertainty written all over her face. The gentle way she smiles at her just makes Catra love her even more. She tugs on the fabric.

"If I take these off…and I put my mouth between your legs… would that be okay? I really want to do that, if that's something you'd like."

Catra's mouth goes dry.

"Yeah…" she answers softly, and she nods to punctuate her agreement. "That would definitely be okay."

Adora cups her cheek briefly, pressing a kiss to her forehead before she seizes the top of Catra's leggings with both hands and slides them gently down her legs. She even drops to her knees and helps Catra step out of them. It's humbling.

"You don't have to…"

Adora smiles up at her. "I know." She kisses her inner thigh gently, a series of little pecks that feel nice but just frustrate Catra because her mouth is so, so close to where she increasingly wants to be touched now and the heat of her breath skitters over the flesh of her thighs, fluttering over the fur there and giving her goosebumps. It's enough to drive her insane. Adora's mouth wanders dangerously close to the apex of her thighs and Catra uses all her self-control not to push her hips toward her. She's so busy trying to keep herself in check that when Adora seals her mouth over her crotch through her underwear she doesn't see it coming and she lets out a loud gasp, her hips bucking hard. Adora

lets out a muffled noise and then Catra can hear her laughing softly. Her tongue runs slowly along her through the fabric.

Catra whimpers Adora's name, moving to spread her legs a little more. Adora runs her tongue over her over and over again and Catra trembles, balling her hands into fists at her sides. She just licks and licks through the fabric and Catra tries not to lose her mind, but it's becoming difficult. The heat of her tongue feels good even without direct contact and the wetness of her mouth is soaking through her underwear but it isn't *enough*. It comes to a point where she can't take it anymore.

"Adora…I need you to take my underwear off…or I'm going to kill you…" she doesn't really mean to say *that*, it's just the frustration talking, but Adora disengages her mouth and laughs, smiling fondly up at Catra in a way that melts her heart.

"Sorry," she tells her, sounding sincere but somewhat amused. "I didn't wanna take it too fast and overwhelm you or anything."

"You won't," Catra promises, giving her a smile that she hopes is encouraging. Adora finally works her underwear carefully down her legs and Catra only bothers stepping out of them with one foot, just leaving them around one ankle in her haste. She's glad that Adora was so vocal about wanting to taste her, because now that's the only thing in the world she can think about and if Adora stopped now she's sure she might wither up and blow away.

"Wow…" Adora whispers, and Catra looks down at her and finds her staring between her legs. Her cheeks heat up.

"*What*?" she asks, and Adora doesn't look away.

"You look so beautiful," she tells her, and Catra doesn't even know how to respond to that. That's not something she'd ever considered…Adora finding *that* beautiful. But as it turns out, it pleases her, if the involuntary purr that rumbles within her is any indication. Adora is kissing her thigh again, kisses featherlight and gentle that turn slowly passionate as she works her way up

toward the place she was staring before. Catra waits impatiently, her heart fluttering in her chest, and when Adora presses a gentle kiss right where she wants her mouth she moans softly. That seems to spur her on and she licks her slowly, her tongue parting her folds and exploring her carefully until she finds her center. The noise Catra makes when her tongue brushes there seems to be enough of an indication for her to do it again and she licks it again and again. Adora's tongue is so warm and wet and it makes Catra squirm, a series of moans and gasps leaving her lips completely against her will.

"Adora…" she moans, looking down to find the blonde looking back up at her, her cheeks flushed. There's something about the sight of Adora with her head between her legs that just *does it* for her and the sensitive spot beneath Adora's tongue suddenly feels even more sensitive. Adora is watching her carefully, and she switches from using the tip of her tongue to the flat of it and that feels even *better*. Their eyes are locked and it feels so ridiculously intimate, though also extremely embarrassing. Adora moves her hand up Catra's thigh, caressing her there and then moving it up between her legs, pulling her mouth away just long enough to spread Catra open and then she's back to work, her eyes squeezed shut and brows knitted with concentration as she finds that spot with her tongue again and this time she seals it between her lips as she massages it with the flat of her tongue.

"Wow…" Catra can't help whispering, her eyes fixed raptly on the sight of Adora ravishing her. It feels so incredibly good that it's hard to even think and Catra's breaths are ragged and shallow, the sounds that are escaping her mouth careless and needy. Adora is clearly giving it her all and it's all she can do to stay upright when her lips and tongue are working so diligently to push her beyond the bounds of her sanity. She's sucking gently now and that coupled with her insistent tongue rubbing there is way too much for Catra to take. How is she supposed to keep from completely falling apart like this?

Adora seems like she's losing control too. Catra slides her tail up to the back of her neck and curls against her there and it seems

to do something to her. Adora moves to shift her without disengaging her mouth, pushing her more firmly against the tree. One strong hand pulls one of Catra's legs over Adora's shoulder and Catra braces herself by grabbing a branch on the side of the tree as Adora's mouth lavishes her with attention even more insistently than before.

Catra gasps her name over and over, a silent mantra and Adora moans against her, her mouth moving almost frantically, one of her hands on Catra's hip to steady her as she moves her other hand to spread Catra open again, giving herself better access, and Catra keens and rocks against her face completely against her own will, drawing another moan from Adora that sends sparks of heat to the place her mouth is working at. The fact that Adora is *moaning* at doing this…the fact that she's doing it at all…it's incredible to Catra, and hard to even believe. She watches the blonde's face, her eyes still squeezed closed and her eyebrows nearly touching. Catra would recognize that focused expression anywhere, and there's something surreal and extremely attractive about the fact that it's on her face not because she's training or focusing on the panel of Mara's ship when something goes wrong, but because she's giving her all to pleasuring Catra.

The more insistently Adora works her mouth on her, the more out of control Catra becomes. She's rolling her hips into her mouth by now, clinging to the branch for dear life as her legs shake and threaten to give out. She grips frantically at Adora's shoulder, struggling to communicate with words as she finds her voice shaky and unable to do much more than babble the other woman's name.

"Adora…" she whispers helplessly, squeezing her and trying not to dig her claws into her. "I…don't know how much longer I can stand up I…my legs are…" Useless, she's going to say, but she doesn't get the chance to before there's a flash of bright golden light and it isn't Adora between her legs, but She-ra. The princess shifts, effortlessly lifting Catra and moving her so her legs rest on the cool metal of where She-ra's breastplate comes out over the sides, supporting Catra's weight with her strong shoulders and

rising to her full height to rest Catra's back higher against the tree, though she winds her arms around her and uses them to hold Catra firmly in place.

Now that Catra isn't supporting her own weight she relaxes, her fingers winding instinctively through strands of glowing platinum hair and pulling She-ra's…*Adora's* face closer to her center. She's rewarded by Adora's tongue resuming its ministrations with renewed vigor, slower and more calculated now that she's got her in a better position. Adora's tongue and mouth as She-ra are much bigger and Catra finds nearly her entire sex surrounded by her lips before she adjusts to provide more accurate stimulation, her lips closing around her right where she wants and applying gentle suction as she continues to lick her slowly with the flat of her tongue.

The heat of Adora's mouth is even more intense as She-ra and Catra feels like she's falling apart. She pulls her hair without even meaning to, her thighs on either side of her head squeezing tighter than she means for them to as she rocks her hips against the princess's face. The sounds that are leaving her own mouth are completely uncontrolled and they sound *filthy* even to her own ears, but she can't bring herself to care about anything but the way it feels to have the person she's loved for as long as she's known how to love making love to her. Whether or not someone might hear, what's going to happen tomorrow, everything that's happened up until now…those thoughts all fall away and all she's left with is the blinding heat of the passion between them, the wet heat of her lover's mouth dragging all of the sanity from her and leaving her completely exposed and vulnerable and uncomfortably hot, her body coated in a sheen of sweat and every muscle she has and some she'd never even noticed before trembling uncontrollably.

"Adora…Adora…Adora…" she gasps, the syllables breaking now and then around mindless noises as she rides her face and clutches at her hair, at the somehow warm metal of She-ra's crown that looks so suspiciously like the mask Catra herself used to wear. Adora's mouth works gently at her with a patient

singlemindedness, a silent promise that she isn't thinking about anything else, that Catra is all she cares about right now, that at least for this moment she's finally all hers. Her thumbs rub gentle circles on Catra's lower back, comforting and tender and coaxing more and more from her with a softness that almost feels like 'I love you' and Catra breaks apart under her hands and mouth, her back arching against the wood of the tree and into She-ra's strong hands as she comes in crashing, brutal waves of inescapable heat and pleasure that threaten to shatter her into nothing. Adora is as stubborn as ever, drawing out as much as Catra has, dragging her orgasm out to what feels like beyond what's ever been possible for her before. Catra doesn't know if it's She-ra's magic or just *Adora* but she comes harder than she ever has in her life, her body hypersensitive and molten hot and so easily yielding to Adora's insistence to give her more and more and it just keeps happening, her rolling hips moving out of control against her mouth.

When it's finally over, Catra's body falls limply against the tree and Adora shifts her, taking her in She-ra's strong arms and holding her close for just a moment before with a bright pop sound she's Adora again and she stumbles, taking a moment to rebalance herself to compensate for the loss of She-ra's immense strength. Catra has the sense that she definitely didn't mean to detransform and she frowns, her breathing coming too shallow to speak just yet. It's a little embarrassing to have Adora holding her bridal style like this, especially when she's completely naked, and Catra wants to squirm away from her. She doesn't.

Adora lowers the two of them slowly to the forest floor, arranging Catra in her lap and cradling her head against her chest. The way she holds her is so bleedingly tender that Catra almost wants to cry. She just lets her do it, holding still against her as she catches her breath, listening to Adora's heart thudding hard against her ear with its powerful, stubborn rhythm. Catra would do anything to keep that heart beating forever, and she feels tears welling in her eyes again when the reality of their situation sets in once more. She's not willing to let herself cry in front of Adora, though. Not right now.

“What was that?” she asks instead, and Adora seems startled.

“What do you mean?”

“You didn’t seem like you meant to stop being She-ra. You’re having problems, is that it?”

“No it’s uh…it’s fine. I’m fine.”

“Don’t lie to me.” Catra sighs, shifting to look at her and placing a hand on Adora’s cheek. She’s sweaty. “What’s going on?”

“I’ve been having problems since the Fright Zone,” Adora admits more readily than Catra expects, and she rubs her thumb in little circles on Adora’s cheek, meeting her eyes. “I don’t know why.”

“Don’t you think that’s going to complicate things?” Catra asks, and Adora squeezes her eyes shut, turning her face away. The glowing mark on her chest flashes a cold blue.

“I don’t want to think about tomorrow right now,” Adora tells her firmly, and Catra is actually proud of her for asserting herself. She uses the hand on Adora’s cheek to tilt her face back to look at her and her eyes open into Catra’s, holding her gaze.

“What do you want, then?” she asks her gently, her thumb still caressing in encouraging little circles. Adora closes her eyes, leaning her cheek into her touch, and Catra can’t help smiling.

“I want to forget about it,” Adora tells her softly, and Catra shifts to hold both her cheeks in her hands. Adora opens her eyes again and they just watch each other.

“You want me to distract you?” Catra asks softly, a note of suggestiveness in her tone as she leans forward, her lips meeting Adora’s softly. Adora melts into her kiss, pulling her closer, and she purrs and opens her mouth, running her tongue along Adora’s lower lip before pulling away, bumping her forehead into hers, Adora’s hair poof smushing against her forehead. “Is that what you want?”

“Catra, I…”

“Hmm?”

“Yes.”

“What do you want me to do?”

“Catra…” this time her voice sounds exasperated. “Don’t make me say…”

“I want to hear you say it. I want to know what you want.”

Adora clears her throat. “I want to feel you too, Catra,” she says shakily, like it’s taking a great amount of effort to admit. “I want to know what it’s like.”

Oh.

Somewhere in there, Catra already knew that Adora probably doesn’t have any experience in this area either, but the sheer realization that she’ll be able to be the one Adora has her first time with is stunning to her and gives her pause. It’s with wonder that she looks her over, still fully clothed save for her jacket that she took off earlier to sleep, and her cheeks are flushed as she watches Catra watching her.

“Are you sure?” she asks, needing confirmation before she does something that she’s been hoping so desperately she would get the chance to do, desperately enough that she’s worried it might impair her judgement. She has to hear how badly Adora wants her, and the blonde doesn’t disappoint, reaching out to touch her hair and smiling at her a bit shyly. She’s never seen Adora look shy before.

“I’m sure,” she tells her softly, biting her lower lip and glancing away before she meets Catra’s eye again. “I want you, Catra. I want you so much. I’ve wanted this for a long time. So please…”

A surge of heat rolls through Catra's stomach at Adora's words, and she doesn't have to ask her twice. Catra descends on her, kissing her hungrily as she runs her hands over her clothed torso, feeling the definition of her muscles through the thin spandex of her compression top and the heat of her skin so, so close to being bare to her. It's everything she can do to keep from just using her claws to rip her shirt to shreds and touch her in a way that's almost feral, but she keeps her composure and kisses her passionately but with control, her hands sliding gently over her and her claws just catching lightly at the fabric now and then instead. She's touched Adora through her clothes before, on her back or side or wherever when they're being playful but never with such intent, and it makes her head swim. As she rolls her tongue frantically against Adora's with just enough self-control not to push herself over the edge of sanity, Adora's hands explore her bare back, the rough callouses of her fingertips giving her goosebumps.

Catra moves her mouth to Adora's neck, kissing and sucking there wherever she can reach over the neck of her high shirt. Adora reacts stronger than she expected, lurching into her kisses and clutching at her back as Catra sucks at her pulse point, her claws running in slow and gentle trails up and down her sides. She's nipping at Adora's soft earlobe when she finally lowers her hands to the bottom of her shirt, giving it a tug as she draws back to meet her eyes.

"Can I?" she asks, waiting for Adora's furious nod before she pulls the stretchy fabric upward, helping Adora out of her top and taking in the sight of her in just her plain sports bra before she returns to her neck. Adora tilts her head back to give her better access, considerate as ever, and Catra lavishes her throat with kisses. She's grateful that the shirt isn't in the way anymore. Adora's pulse speeds up more and more under Catra's lips as she explores the column of her throat, nips at the joint where her neck meets her shoulder, kisses gently along her collarbones and all the way down to where the swell of her breasts begin just above the line of her bra.

Catra can barely believe this is happening and she relishes every moment. Adora is so beautiful to her. She's so achingly beautiful. She burns so bright and she's so warm and full and alive but she's ephemeral, her bright light too brilliant to last long and Catra knows there's every chance she might be gone tomorrow. It aches her, kills her inside in a way that makes tears prickle in her eyes but she wills them away and instead focuses on the taste of Adora's skin, the heat of her body, until the moment passes. It all clicks in this moment; it isn't about Catra. It hurts so bad that she's going to lose Adora, but Adora…Adora is the one who has to pay the price. Adora is the one Shadow Weaver as good as sacrificed. It's Adora who is likely spending her last night here, with Catra. Like this. How afraid must she be? What must be going through her head, knowing she's been robbed of her future? No, this isn't about Catra. This is about Adora. How many times has Adora given up what she wants because it's what she *has* to do? How much has she suffered because no one ever, ever thinks about her?

With renewed intensity, Catra pulls back and grabs at Adora's bra, and Adora seems as desperate as she is to get it off, if the fact that she does most of the work is any indication. Catra barely has to lift a finger. She only takes a brief moment to admire the sight of her naked from the waist up before she descends on her, because as much as she wants to stare, *this isn't about her*. If Adora feels like she has to do this, if Adora is going to give up her life in the name of her infuriating need to always do the *right* thing…if this is going to be her last night because of it…well. Then Catra is going to make it *good*. If she only has one night left, if this is the last chance they'll have to be together like this, she's going to give Adora all she has and she's going to make it worth it to her, even if this is all she can do.

Catra presses light kisses to her breast, painstakingly gentle, and she moves from one to the other, peppering featherlight little pecks there before she trails her mouth back up to Adora's, capturing her lips with her own and kissing her with every ounce of passion in her body, every flicker of desire she's felt and repressed and held back for the woman in front of her since

puberty. Adora moans softly into the kiss and then louder when she lifts her hands to cup her breasts, feeling them gently and caressing them experimentally. Adora leans into her touch, her motions threatening to topple Catra from her lap but she keeps her balance and touches her with even more promise, her fingers shaking. Adora is so warm and the weight of her breasts in her hands makes her feel like she must be dreaming, because there's no way Adora could ever actually let her touch her this way. But she is. She is, against all odds, and Catra can't get enough.

"Do you like this?" she asks Adora, wanting to make sure she's getting what she wants, and Adora nods fervently, her ponytail flopping around with the intensity of it.

"I like it," she promises in a comforting voice, reassuring her, and Catra wonders…does Adora *ever* stop thinking about other people? Does she ever think about herself, even for a moment?

"What else do you like? What do you want me to try?" Catra asks her softly, soothingly, her fingers toying with Adora's nipples and making her whimper softly in a way that's delicious but definitely not what she would have expected. Adora's eyes close and she leans her head back, pushing herself more fully into Catra's hands, little sounds escaping her lips as Catra rolls her nipples between her fingers. "Is there anything you want to feel?"

"I…I don't…whatever you wanna do is fine…"

Hmm. So clearly this isn't working. Adora is just too damn stubborn and self-sacrificing and she's just not wired to easily be able to give in and admit what she wants. If they had more time, Catra is sure she could coax it out of her, but tonight is all they have and so she has to improvise instead. She switches tactics.

"Do you want me to lick these?" she asks Adora gently, her tone placating. "Would you like that?"

"Uh-uh…" Adora breathes, and Catra lowers her head and kisses her right breast again, less chaste this time and more intense.

With her hand still touching her left breast Catra hones in on her nipple and laves it with her tongue, spurred on by the soft sounds that Adora lets out as she tastes her. Adora is so receptive, so quick to fall apart for her and let her guard down completely and to Catra it's the most beautiful thing she's ever seen. She switches her mouth to Adora's other breast, replacing her mouth on the right one with her hand and going to work on making her come undone all over again. Adora whispers her name, so softly, and Catra is going insane. She lowers her free hand between Adora's legs, caressing over her clothed thigh roughly and breaking her mouth away from her nipple just long enough to speak.

"Can I touch you?" she asks, and Adora answers almost immediately.

"Please," she gasps, and her hips lurch forward when Catra's hand cups her through her pants. Even through two layers of fabric Catra can feel her heat and it makes her head swim. She starts rubbing her there, just enough pressure to make her moan.

"Does it feel good?" Catra asks her and Adora's soft moans are answer enough but Adora is just so *good* and she answers her anyway, though it seems to take her quite a bit of effort.

"Yeah," she promises, her voice shaky, and Catra loves her. She loves her with every ounce of strength she has, loves her with every fiber of her being and her love lifts up to the heavens and crashes back down to the forest floor as she rubs and licks and *loves* her with every motion she makes to please her. Her hips are starting to grind against Catra's hand and she pulls her mouth from her breast to look at her. The strands of hair that have escaped from that little poof she wears are starting to stick to her sweaty cheeks, and her skin is flushed.

"More?" Catra asks, to which Adora nods emphatically. "Can I taste you?"

"Please taste me," she gasps, and Catra nearly comes undone at the pure *desire* in her voice. Adora wants her. She wants her. It's a

fact that echoes through her mind over and over as she climbs from Adora's lap, going for the button on her pants and undoing it, sliding down her zipper. Adora lifts her hips to help her take her pants off and Catra caresses her thigh with her palm in gentle encouragement as she pulls them down. Now she's just in her underwear and she's flushed pretty much everywhere and she's the most beautiful thing Catra's ever seen. The impatience with which she drags her own underwear down softens Catra's heart, makes it swell and crash into her as she discards them and looks at Catra, completely naked and breathing quickly and so, so perfect to her.

This time, Catra indulges in just a brief moment where she allows herself to stare because it's the first time she's seen Adora naked in years and she's definitely never seen her naked and turned on before. Adora has always been muscular; it's a given with the military upbringing they both shared. But now, Adora's muscles are more defined in a way that isn't obvious through her clothes. She looks so strong and healthy and beautiful and like everything she could ever want and it kills her a little bit. Catra just…looks at her, and the way Adora meets her stare and doesn't look away is nothing short of exhilarating. She only allows herself a brief look before she shifts, reminding herself that she's not doing this because *she* wants to—though she does—she's doing it for *Adora*.

Catra gathers up Adora's shirt and pants and the discarded pieces of her own outfit, moving behind her to lay them out on the forest floor so Adora can lay back on them.

"Here," she tells her, patting the makeshift bedding gingerly. "It might be more comfortable for you to lie down. I'm not She-ra. I won't be able to hold you up if your legs get too weak to stand."

Adora flushes a deeper red, laughing softly.

"Well thanks," she says warmly, smiling at her as Catra comes back around to sit on her haunches in front of her. "That's really sweet of you, Catra."

She can feel herself flush and looks away, suddenly embarrassed. Inexplicably, she can feel her temper threatening to rise, and she closes her eyes briefly to calm down. When she opens them, she takes in the sight of Adora still smiling gently at her, giving her the same tender look she gave her so many times on their way back to Etheria.

"Don't mention it," she replies quickly, looking away. She can see Adora moving in her peripheral vision and she turns to watch her lying back on the clothes Catra so carefully arranged for her, still giving her an encouraging smile. Catra crawls closer to her, her own heartbeat thudding in her ears. It's hard to believe this is even real. They're naked together here in the Whispering Woods, the smell of Adora's desire very apparent to her sensitive nose, and Catra is about to make love to her. It's almost too much to believe. Adora is lying before her, flushed and expectant but still smiling, the mark on her bare chest glowing a bright warm pink again. She looks so beautiful and tonight, just for these moments…she's all for her.

Catra moves to crawl between Adora's knees and Adora spreads her legs for her and it's the most exciting thing that's ever happened. It's difficult not to just stare between Adora's legs because *this* is somewhere she's never really gotten a good look at, but she does look, long enough that when she looks back up at Adora's face she's flushed even redder, the smile she's still giving her now colored with embarrassment. She wants to tell Adora how beautiful she is, there and everywhere else, wants to tell her how badly she's wanted her for so many years and how all she wants to do is be with her for every second of her life. But she doesn't. Saying anything too emotional would hurt too badly given the situation. She bites her tongue, leaning forward to run her hands up and down Adora's inner thighs. They're trembling.

"Tell me you want this," Catra whispers, so softly that the sound of the wind in the trees nearly drowns it out. "Tell me this is what you want. I want to know what you want."

"I want *you*," Adora tells her, and though it isn't the first time she's said it tonight it still sends shivers down Catra's spine. "I want this. I want this with *you*."

Catra comes down between her legs, resting her weight on her elbows, her stomach coming to rest on the makeshift bed of clothes, though her legs below her knees hang off and press into the cool grass. As she makes herself comfortable, Adora is still and she's quiet. Waiting. The air between them feels heavy with unspoken words and palpable desire and when Catra leans in to press a kiss to Adora's inner thigh she gasps softly, her whole body giving a little lurch at the contact. Catra keeps her mouth there, kissing gently and working her way toward the apex of those strong thighs. The hair there tickles her cheek, but it feels nice. She sucks gently, carefully at the juncture of thigh and pelvis and Adora squirms a little, breathy sounds escaping her mouth. Adora has a mess of dark golden curls between her legs and Catra lowers her mouth beneath it and presses a kiss there. Adora lurches again, a ragged whisper of Catra's name breaking through the soft rhythm of wind and crickets and rustling trees.

"You smell good," Catra whispers, the hunger in her own voice apparent even to her. Adora doesn't answer, just makes a soft sound instead and Catra kisses her there again, once twice, three times and Adora is keening and her hips are quivering so the desperate moan that Adora makes when Catra's tongue runs along her sex is expected but so, so much more delicious than she could have imagined. Her taste is unexplainable, it's musky and intoxicating with a hint of sweat and Catra needs more. She delves her tongue between her folds, tasting every centimeter with a careful reverence that Adora rewards her for with soft needy moans. Catra had assumed that Adora, controlled, repressed, uptight Adora would be quiet and restrained about this but no. Unexpectedly she's loud and she's unabashed and it's the most attractive thing Catra has ever experienced. When her tongue brushes over the center of Adora's pleasure she gasps and grabs a handful of Catra's hair and *pulls*. Wow.

Catra keeps her slow licks centered there, intoxicated by the smoothness of her skin and the smell and taste of her that threatens to drive her insane as she closes her eyes and concentrates on nothing but *her*. It's all she can do not to just go absolutely feral and lick her with wild and needy abandon, but Adora deserves better than that. She wants to give her the absolute best. The extent of her—and probably Adora's too, she thinks—knowledge about sex comes from rumors and the most basic of sex ed the Horde offered and the handful of secret rendezvous they accidentally witnessed briefly in their extensive exploration of the Fright Zone, so of course while she knows enough about it to know the basics of what people do, of what Adora will probably like, when it comes to the finer details she has to run on pure instinct and Adora's reactions and what she liked when Adora did to her to figure out what to do. She seems to react much stronger when she licks her with the flat of her tongue rather than the tip and so she does that, rubbing it against that spot in slow rhythmic motions that have Adora pulling her hair again. That definitely seems like a good sign.

While Catra laves her tongue over the spot Adora likes, her hands come up to caress Adora's hips, her thumbs rubbing circles there, her claws giving her tiny teasing pricks now and then as Adora just falls apart under her tongue. She's moaning and whimpering with reckless abandon and Catra thinks she could get drunk on it, could live in the sounds Adora makes while she makes love to her. Her hips tremble under Catra's hands and her fingers that are laced through Catra's hair tug gently, encouragingly, with each and every brush of her tongue. Catra still can't believe she's doing this, can't believe Adora wants this, wants her, can't believe Adora is reacting like this to being with *her*. It's so incredible to her that she can barely even wrap her brain around it, and she nuzzles her cheek against Adora's inner thigh to show her the words she can't say as she loves her with her tongue.

"Catra…" Adora whispers breathlessly, her fingers tugging at her hair and rubbing at her scalp in a way that feels desperate and helpless. "I want your fingers inside me." Catra is amazed by this revelation and she swears she sees stars, unsure of whether she's

more entranced by the fact that Adora wants her to finger her or by the fact that she told her what she wants unprompted. "Please…will you?"

Even if Catra wanted to, she could never deny Adora anything… and she really doesn't want to. She wants to give Adora everything she wants and she wants to feel her from the inside so much that her head swims. Keeping up dutifully with her tongue's motions she shifts to move her right arm, putting all of her weight on her left elbow so she can trail her fingertips up her thigh. She sheaths her claws carefully and Adora spreads her legs wider as Catra caresses her fingertips over the source of her wetness, her own heart thudding in her ears. Carefully, very carefully, she presses the tip of her index finger to Adora's entrance and slides it slowly inside, taking care to be gentle. It goes easily because Adora is so ready for her and it reminds her all over again that Adora *wants* her. It rolls a knot into her stomach of the most amazing kind.

"Catra…" the way Adora says her name sounds like she's praying. There's such need and reverence in her tone that Catra nearly cries. She accidentally neglects what she's doing with her mouth briefly so she can focus on exploring Adora inside and the heat of her, the smooth slickness…it's enough to render her dumbstruck. She runs her fingertip luxuriously along Adora's front wall, relishing in the feel of her and Adora is making small sounds that crescendo to a loud moan when her finger brushes a place that feels slightly different. Catra keeps her touch centered there when she realizes that the reaction is the same every time, she starts thrusting her fingertip firmly against that spot and relishing the way Adora's legs start to shake.

Catra was so enthralled by fingering Adora that her tongue wasn't pulling its weight and she returns more attention to that, continuing to lick her firmly in the way she's found she likes and trying to match the movement of her finger inside with the rhythm of her tongue. The sounds Adora makes push her onward, pleasuring her with everything she has and getting caught up in the way Adora's legs shake and her hips and tremble. It's beautiful

to be able to get her so out of control way and Catra can barely even believe she's doing it, she's getting to give Adora exactly what she wants and the fact that it's *her* is just almost more than she can take. Adora is exactly what *she* wants and she needs to make this as special and perfect and wonderful for Adora as she is to her. She withdraws her finger to add her middle finger alongside it and curls both of them together against that spot over and over again as Adora starts to move her hips a little against her hand.

Adora says Catra's name again, loud and breathy. Catra wants to make her feel as good as she is and she closes her lips around the smooth bud she's been licking, continuing the same motion with her tongue that Adora likes as she starts to suck gently at her. Adora pulls at her hair again, harder than before, and Catra keeps doing exactly what she's doing. If the world collapsed around them right now she doubts she'd notice and she likes to think Adora wouldn't either.

As she continues on giving her everything she has, Adora's hips are starting to roll helplessly, a mindless motion that makes Catra's heart catch in her chest. She opens her eyes and looks up at Adora and finds her with her eyes open and staring up at the forest canopy above, blank and out of focus. Her lips are parted and her cheeks are flushed bright pink. The sight of her so out of it because of what Catra is doing is mind blowing to her. She's never seen anything so beautiful. Catra moves her tongue and fingers in tandem with every shred of passion she has, every movement feeling like it has intent enough behind it to shatter the stars.

Adora is even more vocal now, the sounds she's making rising in pitch and frequency and crashing into needy cries that sometimes sound suspiciously like Catra's name. She's falling apart completely, Catra can feel it. She can feel it with every pound of Adora's heart that she can feel so intimately, with every heavy breath that Adora releases somewhere above her and every jerk of her hips that she doesn't even seem like she can control. Her fingers are tugging desperately at Catra's hair and it's enough to

hurt a little but she doesn't care. Catra continues working her mouth and fingers in perfect harmony in exactly the way that drags the kind of noises out of Adora that she could never have imagined even in her wildest fantasies. She can feel Adora starting to flutter around her fingers and she knows she's close, knows she's about to fall apart, about to shatter just for her and she presses onward, her free hand's claws kneading gently and rhythmically into Adora's hip.

On either side of her, Adora's legs squeeze Catra shakily, grabbing and releasing her with no real rhythm to it and her hips are jerking and trembling, her fingers no longer pulling at her hair but instead pressing desperately into her scalp, pulling at her like she's trying to draw her even closer. Catra pushes her as close to the stars are she can with every brush of her tongue and curl of her fingers and then Adora blazes as bright as one of them, her legs squeezing her and her hips stilling as she clamps around Catra's fingers, jerks under her tongue. Catra watches her as she falls apart, watches as her fingers clutch at the pile of clothes under her, at the grass further out, watches her eyes clamp shut and her mouth quiver as she lets out a long gasp of Catra's name that crashes into a broken moan. Catra pushes her as far as she can go, pours every bit of energy she has into making Adora's orgasm as intense as possible. The series of noises that she's making now are as needy and desperate as Catra thinks they can possibly be and her legs hold her tightly like Catra is all that's keeping her grounded, all that keeps her from floating away as Catra gives her everything she has to give, desperate and wanting more than anything to give her more, more, more.

When Adora finally relaxes, limp and breathing hard as she flops back onto the pile of clothes, her legs on either side of Catra collapsing, Catra slowly withdraws her fingers from her but keeps her mouth on her, slowing the motions of her tongue but keeping it up as gently and lovingly as she can until Adora's fingers that are still lace through her hair push at her gently.

"It's too much," Adora tells her breathlessly. Catra lets her go, sits up and wipes her mouth with the back of her hand. She examines

the slick on her wrist and then licks it and her fingers clean almost instinctively. Adora flushes brighter and looks away and there's something about her modesty in this moment despite what happened just moments ago that makes Catra want to hold her, want to messily declare her love here on the forest floor and let whatever happens afterward happen.

She does one of two, coming to rest beside Adora and wrap her arms around her, and Adora shifts, moving to lie on her side and hold Catra's waist and their bare chests press together. Adora is warm, so, so warm against her and Catra leans in to press their sweaty foreheads together and Adora kisses her sweetly. It fills her heart to bursting, makes her chest swell and then tighten, a knot forming in her stomach when she remembers she's probably going to lose her for good. It's impossible to forget when they're bathed in the pink light glowing from that bright mark that might as well be a death sentence even when they lie together so close and Adora is so warm and sweet and *alive*. Catra cries, and Adora doesn't ask her why. Adora doesn't say a word. She just keeps holding her close and she kisses her forehead and her lips periodically as Catra just lets herself fall apart and sob in a way she promised herself she wouldn't.

"Why does it have to be you?" she asks when she's calmed down enough that her voice doesn't shake. She can't stand the idea of Adora hearing the tears in her voice even if she's seen her shed them. "Why? Why does it have to be you. It always has to be you. Nobody cares about what you want. Nobody ever asks you what you want! It's not fair, Adora! Why don't you care about that? Why don't you *care* that nobody ever cares what you want?"

"I'm sorry," is all Adora says, and it makes Catra want to scream at her. She wants to get up and rip the branches from the trees, wants to tear apart this world that would take Adora from her piece by piece because though it's Adora she wants to be angry with, Adora she *tries* to be angry with, she can't. Everything is falling apart around them, Adora is so willingly sacrificing any future she might have for the sake of everyone else when no one would do the same for her and it makes Catra *furious*. Everything

is falling apart and Adora just accepts it. That's the worst part. That Catra is angry on her behalf but Adora is the one who's going to die and she just doesn't *care*.

"Don't…be sorry," she says finally, her anger deflating and turning to bitter sadness instead. She closes her eyes and lets Adora pet her back, smoothing the fur there and then wandering down to cling onto her tail like she did when they were children. Back when they had years and years to be together. Catra hates that she squandered three of those years being Adora's enemy and loathing her and fighting her and hurting her when she could have been holding her close and giving her night after night like tonight and trying her best to soothe whatever secret wounds her best friend holds and carries secretly inside, the ones Catra knows are there though Adora would never let anyone see them. Losing Adora stings. Knowing what might have been if Catra hadn't been so blinded by her resentment and bitterness to see what was right in front of her stings. "You don't need to be sorry. You didn't do anything wrong."

"I hurt you," Adora says simply. "I'm so sorry."

"Don't worry about *me*," Catra whispers sharply. "I'm not the one who's gonna *die*, Adora. Why don't you ever think about yourself? Why doesn't it…matter to you that everyone is always so willing to use you however they want? Why doesn't it matter to you how much everyone just…*hurts* you?"

Adora looks stunned, and she closes her eyes and Catra watches the tears gather at their corners before she blinks them away. "I know you don't understand, but I just…it *doesn't* matter, Catra. I don't matter. I can save everyone, and that's what matters. I don't have a choice. I'm sorry."

"Of course you matter!" Catra snarls, pulling her closer, and Adora's eyes shoot open. "You matter to *me*! You matter to your stupid princess friends! You're not important because of She-ra or any of that! *That's* what doesn't matter! You're a *person*, Adora! A person who matters! Don't let Shadow Weaver make you think

that destiny or whatever she got into your head is more important than who *you* are! We can figure something else out! Don't…just give up everything for everyone else. When *do* you get a choice, Adora? If you do this…it might be the last one you make!"

"I'm okay with that!" Adora counters, tears streaming down her cheeks now, and Catra is a little stunned. "If this is my last night, then that's okay! I'm not doing this for Shadow Weaver! I have to keep all of you safe and this is the best way! I can't risk anyone else getting hurt because of me. If I use the failsafe then Prime can *never* use the weapon. If he can get it to it then it's all over, Catra. I have to do this. I can't give him the chance to get his hands on it. I can't let any of you get hurt."

Catra sighs, closing her eyes. "Why are you so willing to do this? Why are you so willing to throw your life away like this?"

"Because it's who I am," Adora tells her simply, and she kisses Catra's forehead and sits up. She shifts to gather her clothes and Catra follows suit. They dress in silence, the heavy rustling of the trees and the chorus of bugs their only accompaniment. When Adora stands and lets her hair down, redoes her ponytail so it's immaculate and tight and just so, so *Adora*, Catra finally knows what to say.

"That isn't who you are," she tells her firmly, closing her hands around Adora's upper arms. "Who you are is…Adora. Who you are is the girl I grew up with stealing extra ration bars and sneaking into every place we weren't allowed to go. Who you are is the girl who cares so much about her friends that she acts like an idiot. Who you *are* is whoever you want to be. Who you *choose* to be. It doesn't have to be this way. Please."

The smile Adora gives her is sad, that mark blazing a cold and melancholy blue that goes so well with Catra's feelings she feels like she should be the one wearing it. And really, she should. She deserves to lose everything. Adora doesn't. "It does though, Catra. Maybe there could be some other way. But we don't have enough time. I can't risk it. I really can't. I have a chance to be

okay. No one else does. For anyone else it's a death sentence. For me, there's a chance."

"You can't transform!" Catra growls, swiping the air with her claws in agitation. She can feel her tail thrashing. "It is a death sentence for you too and you know it! So stop acting like this is somehow the lesser of two evils! I took…*so* much from you! It should be *me* who has to die! Not you!"

"Don't say that!" Adora rarely raises her voice like *that*, and Catra is driven to silence by it. "You deserve just as much of a chance to live as anyone else! You don't get to say that!"

Silence hangs between them for a long moment, and Catra doesn't know what to say. She wants to argue, but she doesn't want to make Adora even more upset than she already is. She can give her that much, at least. Adora is crying silently now, and she turns away from Catra and leans against the tree She-ra had her up against not that long ago. Catra can't help the way her cheeks flush when she remembers. She wants to go to Adora, wants to hold her and comfort her but she just stands there uselessly, watching her strong shoulders shake as she tries to keep her sobs silent. Mostly, she succeeds. The punishment for openly showing weakness when they were children was often worse than whatever they could possibly be crying about in the first place. She knows Adora must have internalized the same fear of breaking down she has. It's painful to watch her like this, an adult, a woman who's gotten away from the Horde and from Shadow Weaver and yet she still carries those scars in the form of the way her cries are absolutely silent.

It doesn't take long for Adora to pull herself together and when she does there's a frown on her face but no further trace of her previous vulnerability. She comes to Catra and touches her cheek, her fingertips so gentle that Catra nearly breaks.

"Thank you for tonight," she tells her steadily, no trace of tears in her tone. "I've…always wanted that. To be close with you in that way. Thank you for what you gave me."

"Yeah…" it comes out pitifully. Catra wants to say something else, but she can't even manage it.

"Catra…" Adora lets out a long breath, and she can tell she's steeling herself. "I understand why you want to leave, and I can't stop you. But I just…I…" the pain on her face is sudden and it crushes Catra's heart like a vice grip. "Just for tonight…please… stay. If you want to leave in the morning I promise I won't bother you. I won't say a word. But I'm…afraid." Catra can tell how much it takes out of her to admit it. "I know what's probably going to happen, and I can put on a brave face all I want but it doesn't change how much it…scares me. I know it's what I have to do but I'm…afraid to die."

"Adora…" Catra cups her cheeks in both hands and Adora kisses her so gently that it's like she thinks she's made of glass.

"Please stay with me tonight. I know it's a lot to ask but…I need you. I can't do this alone. Not right now."

Catra's heart shatters, softened by the fact that Adora feels comfortable enough to *ask* for something. It's so humbling and though it's absolutely terrifying to think of staying when she knows what might happen, she nods solemnly, reaching to take Adora's hand and she squeezes it tight. Adora squeezes back.

"I'll stay. Just for tonight," she promises, giving Adora an encouraging smile, though she's sure it doesn't reach to her eyes. "Don't worry. I won't make you spend the night alone."

Adora's lip trembles and she looks away briefly before she gives Catra a smile of her own. Her eyes are damp, but the pink glow on her chest speaks words that she doesn't.

"Thank you, Catra."

"Yeah, yeah. When have I ever been able to say no to you?" Catra's words are playful but her heart is heavy and as they walk back into the shelter together it's everything she can do to keep from falling apart. Catra doesn't sleep at all that night. She lies on

Adora's bedroll with her and holds her close as she sleeps, toying with her hair and inhaling her scent with every breath because she knows she might not be able to do it ever again after the sun rises.

In the morning Catra ignores the light teasing Glimmer tries on the two of them in an obvious attempt to lighten the mood about everyone waking up to find them cuddling. She barely speaks a word. Last night it would have been so easy to slip away, but this morning she has to deal with the uneasy silence of the others as she says her brief goodbyes and pulls herself away with Melog at her side. Her heart feels heavy in a way that makes it hard to carry, especially when Adora slips her hand into hers for just a moment the instant before she leaves for good. She squeezes Catra's hand, and then she lets go. She lets go and Catra leaves without looking at her, unceremonious and resolved.

Her heart doesn't feel light again until Prime is dead and Adora holds her close again. Until she knows Adora loves her too.

Then, it feels weightless.

End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! I'm working on like three other fics right now so I'm sure one of them will likely be up soon c:

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!